



Account recovery using backup email is not working

I am trying to recover an account for a close friend who does not have internet access and no longer has the phone or phone number associated with his account. He has not logged into his account for several years, but he has valuable data on his Google Drive he needs to recover.

When we go through the process on my computer, we try to log in with his email address and password and it says it doesn't recognize the device, so we need to log in another way. The only options it lists is to text or call the phone number he no longer has access to. So we know the password is correct. Since we don't have the phone number, we click Get Help. This starts the account recovery process and it asks for the last password we remember. We give it the current password. Then it once again asks to text or call the phone. We click "I don't have this phone." It asks the security question. We answer it. Then it asks us to verify the recovery email address so it can send us a verification code. We do this, it sends us a code, and we verify the code successfully. Then it says thank you for verifying that he has access to this email address, but it still can't verify his identity. That's it. No more questions or options.

We're fairly confident we're answering the security question correctly since it's all numeric, but we've tested it with a nonsense answer to see if it tells us when we're wrong, and the result is exactly the same. So we can't verify whether or not the answer we're giving to the security question matches what is on file, though as I said, we think we're answering it correctly.

What is thoroughly baffling is why using the recovery email address is not sufficient. Wasn't that the whole point of adding a recovery email address? If we verify that he has access to the recovery email address, and it says we've verified that, why isn't that enough? And if that isn't enough, why does it

bother to ask for it in the first place? It didn't ask any questions after that or give us any other options, so what was the point of the recovery email?

How do we solve this? The only thing we don't have is his old phone. Surely it's not unusual that people change phones and phone numbers. And of course we're using an unrecognized device and location (mine) to try to log in. As mentioned, he doesn't have internet access (or his old computer) so using my device and location is his only option. We have the account name, the current password, the answer to the security question, and access to the recovery email address. Surely that's more than enough to verify his identity!

Details

[Account Access & Recovery](#), [Web](#), [details_gmail](#)

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All Replies (10)



jp88  **Diamond Product Expert**

Volunteer helper in Google Account, and Gmail forums. Not a Google employee.

Feb 2, 2020



Jeremiah Mercier

If you do not know the Gmail/Google account log in credentials, or have trouble accessing the Gmail/Google account, then you will need to undertake Account Recovery ("AR"). There is no other way.

Please note the following:--

- For lost passwords, if applicable, check the password managers in your browser, or installed on your device.
- If you find your password; all good, no further assistance should be required.
- Otherwise, Google will not return the account if you can't provide enough information to convince them as to "ownership" of the account.
- The decision is made by Google; not by the volunteer helpers in this forum. We do not know the criteria Google use.
- The response may be delayed by Google, depending on the complexity of your problem.
- Account Recovery ("AR") is the ONLY way to recover the account.
- If you are unwilling to undertake AR, Google will refuse all further assistance.
- There is no personal service from Google for free Gmail accounts. All help in the forum only, at no charge.
- Do not use scammers advertising in the internet, or posting here \$\$\$, can't help, may install ransomware, not associated with Google.
- Don't know the account name? Select "Forgot email" in the first step. Without account name, recovery is not possible.
- You can't choose the questions Google ask, and we don't know how or why they choose these questions, and not others.
- "Security" questions may no longer be asked. Google has deprecated these.
- Hacked, and Google offer to send a Verification Code to an email address changed by the hacker? Select "Try Another Way".
- For account creation date, if needed, read <https://support.google.com/accounts/thread/2394368?msgid=2420513>
- When attempting AR, use, if possible, a device, browser, location, and connection type that recently allowed you to access the account.
- Don't use a VPN when attempting AR.
- When answering a question, be as accurate as possible, or "Choose Another Question" / "Try Another Way".
- If a hacker changed recovery details, insert the details you set up, if asked for this information.
- ID or documentation of any kind is not accepted by Google. Neither of these prove rightful account "ownership".
- We cannot personally assist you in this process. Only the account claimant can complete the AR.
- Now read [Gmail account recovery](#) to understand the process.

Next thing to do:-

- Go to [Recover your Google Account or Gmail](#), follow the steps in that link.
- ONCE ONLY! (**one more time please, even if you have previously tried**).
- There is no other way to regain access.

What did Google say AFTER you submitted the Account Recovery? May have been by email, or on screen when you completed the process. (Redact anything personal). We need to know this, in order to provide you with more assistance, if possible.



Jeremiah Mercier Original Poster

Feb 2, 2020



Thank you for your response.

We **do** know the log in credentials and we **do** have the current, correct password, as I explained in my original post. The problem is that we are using an unrecognized device and it is trying to verify his identity using a phone that he no longer owns. I explained this in my original post.

We **are** using the account recovery process, as I explained in my original post. And I have thoroughly and carefully read the help pages.

You asked for the exact message from Google after completing Account Recovery. This is the exact message:

Couldn't sign you in

*****@gmail.com

Thanks for confirming that you can access the contact email address you provided.

Unfortunately Google couldn't verify that *****@gmail.com belongs to you.

Learn more about how to [recover your account](#).

Use another account



jp88  Diamond Product Expert

Volunteer helper in Google Account, and Gmail forums. Not a Google employee.

Feb 2, 2020



Jeremiah

Thanks for the coming back with that information.

Google should soon be sending, to you, (usually within the next 24 - 48 hours), a request for more details, to assist them in *personally* evaluating your case.

The email from Google will be delivered to the same account which you are using to post here, and you must also reply from this account. In the meanwhile, no more recovery attempts!

Take time with your reply, and be as accurate as possible. Google employees will be making the final decision, not the volunteers assisting in this forum. And Google do not accept ID, or documentation of any kind.

(We don't know the criteria Google use in evaluating these issues, this information is not shared outside the AR team at Google.

However if Google reply with a message starting with "*Unfortunately, based on the information you provided, we were unable to verify your ownership*" (or similar), probably nothing more can be done, and Google are not able to restore your access. We usually can't help any further.)



Jeremiah Mercier Original Poster

Feb 2, 2020



I'm confused by your reply. You said that Google would be emailing me for further information within 24-48 hours. Why do you say that? I would welcome such an email, but nothing in the account recovery process seemed to indicate that.

You followed that up by saying that if I received a message along the lines of "we were unable to verify your ownership" then nothing more can be done. That's basically the message I received in the account recovery process, which I copied-and-pasted in my previous response: "Unfortunately Google couldn't

verify that *****@gmail.com belongs to you." Is that the message you're referring to?

I'm still very confused and frustrated by this whole process. We the *correct* password! *And* we have verified access to the recovery email address! How is that not enough to get into the account?!?



jp88 ★ Diamond Product Expert

Volunteer helper in Google Account, and Gmail forums. Not a Google employee.

Feb 3, 2020



| How is that not enough to get into the account?!?

No idea of the criteria Google use, and they will not reveal it.

And Google did reach out to you, 17 minutes ago.



Scott Breedlove

Feb 3, 2020



Trying to get in my old google account scottbreedlove38@gmail.com



Jeremiah Mercier Original Poster

Feb 3, 2020



@Scott, please create a new thread rather than hijacking this thread. Thank you.



Jeremiah Mercier Original Poster

Feb 3, 2020



@jp88, thank you, I did indeed receive an email from Google Support last night. It contained a link to fill out a form to escalate the issue. I filled out the form describing my issue, much the same as in my original post here. The escalation

form did not ask for any specific information to verify my identity. I presumed that would occur in response to my request. It asked for a contact email so I used the account recovery email address so there would no question of identity.

This morning there were three emails from Google in that inbox for that email address. The first one had a subject line of "[#8-1915000029054] Your Google Account Recovery Request" and stated "We'd like to help you get back into your account. We're committed to returning accounts to verified owners, but we can't verify that you own *****. Click the link below to help us verify that you're the owner. <https://www.google.com/accounts/recovery> **Note:** We can't accept identification documents as proof of ownership. **Having trouble? Try these tips.** During the recovery process, we never ask for your password or sign-in info for other sites."

The second email had a subject line of "Your Google Support Inquiry: Case ID [9-7631000028981]" and stated "Unfortunately, based on the information you provided, we were unable to verify your ownership over the account you escalated. We're committed to returning accounts only when we're sure that we're giving them back to their owners. To confirm that you're the owner, we need specific details during the recovery process. We can't accept identification documents as a proof of ownership because we don't consider that a secure method. If you're having trouble, [try these tips](#) when attempting the [account recovery flow](#) (*please note that Google will never ask you for your password or your sign-in information for any other site*)."

The third email had a subject line of "Re: [8-1915000029054] Share your experience with us" and stated "Thanks for contacting us about your account. At Google, we want to make sure you get the help you need. Let us know about your experience with us. **Take survey** Your feedback helps us improve the support experience."

All three emails were received before I had time to respond to take any action on the first one. Of course, the first one is simply redirecting me back to the account recovery process and I've already attempted that process multiple times before my original post. So Google didn't request any additional information as a result of my escalation request and apparently they've already closed the request. It doesn't appear that accomplished anything.

The problem here seems really simple: I'm trying to log in from an unrecognized device and I no longer own the phone linked to the account. But I do have the correct credentials, the answer to the security question, and access to the account recovery email address. I thought the whole reason for having a security question and account recovery email address was precisely for this kind of situation. If I can't use them to verify my identity, what good are they?

What else can I try?



jp88  Diamond Product Expert

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Feb 3, 2020



Jeremiah

Sorry that you have not managed to recover access to the account.

Google do not reveal the criteria used by the AR team. Only a select few in Google would have such information, and it is not shared. Also, as we are not Google employees, just volunteers helping out in our spare time, under Google supervision.

Consequently, we have no idea of the back office tools that Google use, and any account information to which they may have access. We can't give any further useful tips here.

However Google do use other methods, as well as just the simple question/s that you were asked, to assess these cases. And a Google employee/account recovery specialist does personally evaluate each recovery attempt, using the information which you have supplied.

You will need to follow the suggestions (if any) from Google; there is now no other way to recover the account.

*If Google are not **100%** convinced that you are the rightful account user, then they cannot return access .*

Some people have reported that by simply changing the browser, they have managed to recover the account, One other person reported success after waiting a week before trying again. One other poster had luck trying incognito/private mode in their browser, on their desktop device. Small print:- YMMV.

Have a look at this link:- [Tips to complete account recovery steps](#)

Unfortunately we can't help you any further with account recovery, only the claimant can do satisfy Google as to ownership. This recovery is now between yourself, and Google, due to various privacy legislative requirements. (GDPR etc.). Nothing we can add now, in this public forum.



JenniferW

Feb 25, 2020



It sounds like google did what a lot of companies do when faced with regulation that challenges their operating model. Rather than truly innovate a customer-focused solution that is compliant, they pout and run off to the lawyers and generate the clunky, bureaucratic solution for security management to say "so i did what you asked for na na na na na na". I'm basically in purgatory with my google analytics account because of a similar situation and got bounced around for TWO MONTHS before finally ending up at a phone number that requires a pin that I don't have because I don't have admin rights to g-suite.They are using the GDPR as an excuse--they were lazy about privacy, got regulated because of it, and now they are being lazy about how they comply with it, and just letting lawyers drive product design.

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